Throughout the Vedic era, various traditions were formed. A number of religious texts emerged including the Ramayana, the Puranas, the Upanishads and the Mahabharata.

During the sixth century BCE, India saw great religious change due to Vardhaman Mahavira (549 – 477 BCE) and Siddhartha Gautama (563 – 483 BCE). Both of these individuals denounced the traditional religious beliefs and founded their own religions, namely Jainism and Buddhism. Many city states were built and expanded with a growing population as these religions became popular. India's reputation grew as the country prospered into major urban centres. It was at this time that Cyrus of Persia turned his attention towards India. In 530 BCE, he planned a military campaign and marched on India. Within ten years, Persia had gained complete control over India. Cyrus was succeeded by Darius I who forced his own religion and culture upon the Indian people. Although much of Persian culture still exists today, the Hindus were mostly able to preserve their culture and religion.